



Academic Year 2026-27

Grade: MYP 3

Subject: Individuals and societies (IH)

Unit: How are societies governed?

Key concept: Systems

Related concept: Identity, Power

Global context: Fairness and Development

Global context exploration: Students will explore access to equal opportunities; peace and conflict resolution.

Statement of inquiry: Effective governance systems can promote equitable opportunities and peaceful conflict resolution while balancing diverse identities and interests.

Handouts on the concept of systems and identifying various forms of government and their way of functioning

CONNECTION OF SOI AND TOPIC

The Statement of Inquiry, "The identity and power of past societies can be explored through effective governance systems is intricately connected to the topic of Governance and its functions. By examining various governance structures—such as monarchies, republics, empires, and democracies—across different historical periods, we gain insights into how power was distributed and exercised. These systems of governance significantly shaped the social, economic, and cultural identities of societies. For instance, the democratic principles of ancient Athens laid the foundation for modern political thought, while the centralized power of the Roman Empire influenced administrative practices in subsequent European kingdoms. By studying these governance models and their evolution over time, we understand how they affected societal norms, citizen engagement, and the overall stability and identity of societies. This exploration not only helps us comprehend the past but also informs our understanding of contemporary governance and its impact on society.

BACKGROUND

Governance and society have been deeply intertwined throughout history, shaping the development and identity of civilizations. Governance refers to the systems, structures, and processes through which authority is exercised and decisions are made and implemented within a society. Different forms of governance, such as monarchies, democracies, oligarchies, and empires, have influenced how power is distributed and who holds it. These forms of governance affect social hierarchies, economic policies, cultural norms, and individual rights. Over time, shifts in governance have led to significant societal changes, such as the transition from feudal systems to nation-states or the rise and fall of empires. By studying the historical context of governance, we gain insight into how societies function, how they maintain order, and how they respond to challenges and changes. This understanding helps us appreciate the complexities of governance and its profound impact on societal development.

"Good governance is not about making correct decisions. It is about the best possible process for making those decisions." - Raghuram Rajan

INTRODUCTION

Understanding how different governance systems shape societies is crucial for comprehending global dynamics. This handout explores three primary forms of government: Monarchy, Democracy, and Dictatorship. Each system has unique structures, policies, and impacts on citizens' lives. By examining real-life examples, we can gain a deeper insight into how these systems operate and influence both national and international affairs.

Understanding different systems

1. MONARCHY

Structure

- Definition: A political system based upon the undivided sovereignty or rule of a single person. The term applies to states in which supreme authority is vested in the monarch, an individual ruler who functions as the head of state and who achieves his or her position through heredity. Most monarchies allow only male succession, usually from father to son.



“The British Monarchy Helped Mortgage Our Collective Future.” *Time*, time.com/6212672/queen-elizabeth-death-empire-climate-change/.

- Types:
 - Absolute Monarchy: The monarch has almost complete power and authority over the government and the people.
 - Constitutional Monarchy: The monarch’s powers are limited by law or a formal constitution. The government is often run by elected officials, and the monarch serves a more ceremonial role.

- Policies and Characteristics:

- Absolute Monarchy:

- ❖ The monarch makes all major decisions.
- ❖ No or limited political freedoms for the populace.
- ❖ Examples: Saudi Arabia.

- Constitutional Monarchy:

- ❖ The monarch's role is symbolic.
- ❖ Elected parliament or assembly makes laws.
- ❖ Examples: United Kingdom, Japan.

Saudi Arabia (Absolute Monarchy): The King has vast powers over the state. Strict laws based on Islamic Sharia.



Salman bin Abdulaziz Al Saud is King of Saudi Arabia, reigning since 2015, and served as Prime Minister of Saudi Arabia from 2015 to 2022.

United Kingdom (Constitutional Monarchy): Queen Elizabeth II (as of 2023) serves as the ceremonial head of state. The Prime Minister and Parliament handle legislative and executive powers.



Queen Elizabeth first worked with Churchill. Churchill served as Prime Minister from 1940-45, and then again from 1951-55. After she ascended the throne in 1952

2. Democracy

Structure

- Definition: Democracy is a system of government in which laws, policies, leadership, and major undertakings of a state or other polity are directly or indirectly decided by the “people,” a group historically constituted by only a minority of the population (e.g., all free adult males in ancient Athens or all sufficiently propertied adult males in 19th-century Britain) but generally understood since the mid-20th century to include all (or nearly all) adult citizens.



Athens Acropolis

Cartwright, Mark. "Athenian Democracy." *World History Encyclopedia*, 3 Apr. 2018, www.worldhistory.org/Athenian_Democracy/.

- Types:
 - Direct Democracy: Citizens directly participate in decision-making.
 - Representative Democracy: Citizens elect representatives to make decisions on their behalf.

- Policies and Characteristics:

- Regular free and fair elections.
- Protection of individual rights and freedoms.
- Rule of law.
- Separation of powers among branches of government.
- Examples: United States, India.

United States (Representative Democracy): The President, Congress, and Judiciary are separate branches. Citizens vote for representatives at federal, state, and local levels.



House of Representatives
United States government

Switzerland (Direct Democracy Elements): Citizens vote directly on many important policies and laws through referendums.



Citizens assembling in an open public space to vote on various issues in Glarus, Switzerland, 2006.

3. Dictatorship

Structure

- Definition: Dictatorship is, a form of government in which one person or a small group possesses absolute power without effective constitutional limitations. The term dictatorship comes from the Latin title dictator, which in the Roman Republic designated a temporary magistrate who was granted extraordinary powers to deal with state crises.

- Characteristics:
 - No democratic processes or elections are rigged.
 - Limited or no political freedoms and civil liberties.
 - Rule by decree, censorship, and propaganda.



- Policies
 - Centralized control over all aspects of life.
 - Suppression of opposition and dissent.
 - Control over media and propaganda to maintain power.

- Real-Life Examples

North Korea:

- Kim Jong-un rules with absolute power.
- Strict control over citizens' lives, media, and information.



Belarus:

- President Alexander Lukashenko has maintained power through controversial elections and suppression of opposition.



Comparative Analysis

Aspect	Monarchy	Democracy	Dictatorship
Power Source	Monarch (hereditary or symbolic)	Elected representatives/citizens	Single leader/ small group
Political Freedom	Limited (absolute) or High (constitutional)	High	Very Limited
Decision-Making	Monarch or Parliament	Elected Bodies	Dictator
Examples	Saudi Arabia, UK	USA, India	North Korea, Belarus

FURTHER EXPLORATION

1. **Explain** how the structure of each government system impacts the daily lives of citizens.
2. **Discuss** the pros and cons of having a single ruler versus elected representatives.
3. **Evaluate** how different governance systems influence global relations and trade.

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